



Xiaomi 13 Ultra

I got a chance to test the Xiaomi 13 Ultra recently and its camera surprised me!

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In April 2023, Xiaomi took its biggest leap in mobile photography with the launch of the Xiaomi 13 Ultra in China. This phone takes the Xiaomi x Leica collaboration to the next level with an upgraded main 1-inch sensor and perks such as variable aperture, focal length flexibility, and much more. I recently got my hands on the unreleased Xiaomi 13 Ultra for one whole day and I immediately got to testing the camera behemoth. Xiaomi was kind enough to arrange a photo tour across the hills of Coonoor to test out the Xiaomi 13 Ultra – however, the thoughts I express in my first impressions of this camera system are mine alone. The phone is, unfortunately, not launching in India, but it is coming to the European market. With that, let's delve into my first impressions of the Xiaomi 13 Ultra's camera system and why I think that this is definitely the absolute best portrait camera phone on the market now.

Camera specifications

The Xiaomi 13 Ultra flaunts a quad-

camera setup consisting of a 50 MP OIS-enabled Sony IMX989 1-inch sensor with a 23 mm focal length and variable f/1.9 or f/4.0 aperture. Variable aperture means you can control the amount of light coming through the lens, and the depth of field effect can also be managed. So, if you are taking a shot where you want only the foreground to be in focus – f/1.9 works wonders, and if you want the background and foreground to be equally crisp – go for f/4.0 as long as there's enough light. The main camera also supports 50 MP RAW which provides a lot of post-production freedom.

There's a 50 MP periscope telephoto camera that allows you to click 120 mm shots with 5x optical zoom, a 50 MP telephoto lens with 3.2x optical zoom that clicks 75 mm shots, and finally, a 50 MP ultrawide camera which clicks 12 mm focal length photos. There's also support for 5cm macro photography on this phone. So, this is a quad 50 MP setup where each camera has been given equal resolution, so the photos appear more consistent. There's also a 32 MP selfie camera up front, that we didn't get to test a whole lot in our

limited time with the device. The portrait system allows access to four fixed focal lengths – 35 mm Documentary, 50 mm Swirly Bokeh, 75 mm Portrait, and 90 mm Soft Focus via optical and digital zooming capabilities. The main camera supports two photographic styles – Leica Authentic and Leica Vibrant. Authentic has more true-to-life colours, Vibrant adds an extra pop of colour and contrast. So, you can choose as per your preference and the setting. There are also various Leica filters you can choose from – my favourite being the Leica BW High Contrast for portraits.

The advantage of having a large 1-inch sensor is great low-light photography as well since the lens can take in adequate amount of light to output a crisp shot. Xiaomi calls this Ultra Night Photography. The OEM manufacturer also added a multi-layer coating to the lens which reduces glare and ghosting that's usually prominent in night-time shots. The wide aperture of the lens also means shorter shutter speeds – so you can even capture some moving objects and get a crisp output.

Another cool feature is the new Fast Shot mode that lets you manually choose a focus point and camera to shoot from and capture shots instantly with just a double click of the power button. This is useful when you want to take multiple shots in a blink of an eye and you don't have the time to manually choose the lens and set a focus point.

For video, you've got support for Dolby Vision content up to 4K at 60 fps, 8K video recording at 24 fps across all focal lengths, 10-bit LOG video recording, and Director Mode (where you can chain 4 Xiaomi 13 Ultras and control them via one central 13 Ultra). It's safe to say the Xiaomi 13 Ultra is absolutely packed with camera-centric features – many of which aren't just gimmicks but actually quite nifty for budding phone photographers.

Camera quality

With the specifications and camera features out of the way, let's delve into my experience using the Xiaomi 13 Ultra's